

Veiled JIHADIS

Women become new weapons of terror timed with the polls

Armey Chief General Deepak Kapoor may have been the first to officially admit that women were being trained in terror camps across the Loc to infiltrate into India but intelligence agencies have been talking about it for quite some time now. The latest inputs reveal that women are being trained, not merely to target political rallies and leaders during elections, but also to assume the role of handlers for coordinating operations and giving directions to terrorists. According to sources, women are the new weapon of choice because they are not allowed to be frisked by male army personnel because of the sensitive situation in J&K. The army and intelligence agencies have now sought deployment of more women police personnel in the state during elections. The worst

armed with high quality winter gear, including ice-axes, snow boots, multi-layered clothing and parkas. The terrorists intercepted at Kupwara also had GPS devices, detailed maps of the jungles in the higher reaches and satellite phones. "It's a big risk that the terrorists are taking since the visibility in the snow is extremely good. So there are high chances of them being detected. They have been using patches of bad weather to make their move. That's not an easy task. So their motivational levels are high," says one security official.

The motivation is also connected to the timing. Home Ministry officials say that they were prepared for increased activity on the Loc considering the declared intention of Pakistan-based terror outfits to disrupt the polls. "Huge voter turnout during the J&K Assembly polls was a big setback for them. Now their complete focus is disruption of the Lok



ASHIYA BEGUM (RIGHT) IN A J&K PRISON AFTER HER ARREST

fears of intelligence and security forces were confirmed when the J&K Police had arrested Ashiya Begum, 25, from the Sunderbani area of Rajouri district while she was trying to infiltrate in November last year. She disclosed that 700 women were being trained in ISI-run camps at Bhimbar, Kotil and Sinsa where they were being also shown video footage of the fencing on the Loc and taught how to breach it. According to her interrogation report from Jammu Jail, there are already a number of women terrorists operating in India.



A T-SHIRT SEIZED FROM A TERRORIST IS DISPLAYED AT AN ARMY BASE IN SRINAGAR

Sabha polls," explains a senior official looking after internal security.

Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and Home Minister P. Chidambaram confirmed that the threat level due to infiltrations is high. Chidambaram said that four Pakistan-based terror outfits were "working in consort". The Let, Jaish-e-Mohammed, Jamaat-ul-Mujahideen and the Hizbul-Mujahideen were earlier operating separately but have come together now, as revealed by intelligence intercepts. Chidambaram also confirmed that there have been several references to Taliban presence in parts of northern Kashmir, including Kupwara and Gurez, but maintained that it is too early to be sure.

Though one teenaged terrorist, Zamir, was captured alive in the Kupwara encounter and he was from the North-West Frontier Province (NWFP), sources in the intelligence agencies said that he did not belong to the Taliban. They said that it appears that terrorists are being hired from the NWFP and Balochistan. Army Chief General Deepak Kapoor, however, denied the presence of Taliban, though he did raise the issue of women fighters being infiltrated. The Taliban scare could also be for misleading security forces, say intelligence sources. They admit, however, that the new groups of intruders are qualitatively different from earlier ones. There are also indications that they are not from the traditional militant bases like Punjab and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir.

The army has already moved up almost 800 Rashtriya Rifles men to deal with the onslaught. According to an Intelligence Bureau report, between 400 and 500 militants are still waiting to sneak across the Loc apart from the 800-900 militants already present in J&K. That's a daunting prospect considering that a number of paramilitary personnel have been moved to election-related security duties elsewhere in the country. Election-2009 is already turning out to be the most volatile in recent years. Now, the jihadi factor has added another twist to the tale. ■